

ing power within the PPP, lies with an as-yet unelected Zardari, while the prime minister has been reduced to an implementer. But perhaps a greater issue as far as coalition politics is concerned, is what many in the PPP see as Sharif's double game—"enjoying a taste of power without any of the responsibility" in the words of one commentator. Sharif's party has consistently dissociated itself from any of the tougher decisions taken by the government, while continuing to occupy positions within the Cabinet and declaring its "support" to the Government.

Now that Musharraf was gone, the battle for dominance between Zardari and Sharif had truly begun. They immediately squabbled over when the judges should be reinstated with Sharif insisting that Zardari honour his commitment to do it "immediately after" Musharraf's resignation.

ousting of Musharraf. But judicial restoration would be a clear victory for Sharif who had championed the lawyers' cause. The battlelines are being redrawn. Zardari knows Sharif is the leader now to beat and will do everything to prevent an early election. Sharif would want an election at some stage but as retired Lt. Gen. Talat Masood says, "He would not want to pull the plug immediately as he would be perceived as being opportunistic."

The bonhomie between the two is already missing. Sharif has complained to friends that he finds it difficult to get Zardari to keep his word. Mushahid Hussain, a long-time political observer and now general secretary of the PML(Q) thinks the growing tension has a lot to do with their differing styles. He thinks Sharif is an "urban Lahorite" who is impatient to get things done and like one-day cricketers is willing to hit out. In contrast,

THE WAR MONGER: Appointed army chief in 1998 by Nawaz Sharif. Launches the Kargil incursion in May 1999. After a massive loss of lives on both sides, Pakistan withdraws under US pressure in July. He leads a coup after Sharif attempts to sack him on October 12, 1999. India and Pakistan almost go to war after a terror attack on the Indian Parliament in 2001.



THE BENIGN DICTATOR: Styling himself as the chief executive of Pakistan, he vows to improve economy and focus on the liberal vision of Pakistan's founder Mohammad Ali Jinnah. Brings minorities and women into political mainstream, opens up electronic media, and promotes the arts. Charms world media.

THE ARTFUL DODGER: Gets 'elected' as President in a referendum. Rigs elections

in October 2002 and comes to power. Cuts deals with religious parties to vest total powers in the presidency. Even makes peace with Benazir Bhutto in 2007.

THE FRUSTRATED DIPLOMAT: Modelling himself as "a soldier who desires peace" he makes a historic trip to Agra in July 2001 for talks with prime minister A.B. Vajpayee. But talks fail when Musharraf overreaches himself. Talks with new Prime Minister Manmohan Singh do not make much progress.



AMERICA'S GENERAL: Makes a swift turnaround after 9/11 and becomes America's pointsman against Al Qaida and the Taliban. Critics accuse him of handing over militants to the US. Hundreds, including political activists, disappear.

THE GIANT BUNGLER: Sacks a defiant chief justice in March 2007, causing a civil society upheaval. Imposes martial law in November but Bhutto's assassination on December 27, seals his fate. His opponents win polls, forcing him to resign.

BAD OLD WAYS UNDER THE NEW COALITION GOVERNMENT.

Zardari used the timing as a bargaining chip to get a PPP's nominee to become the president. He also claimed to Sharif that he was under "a lot of pressure" to provide indemnity to Musharraf as a part of the guarantee to the army. It was another matter that such an indemnity would make the NRO immune to scrutiny.

Zardari may have won round one by the smooth

Zardari comes from the deserts of Sindh where patience is as ingrained as is survival. So he speaks in loud whispers and exasperates Sharif with his long, drawn-out negotiations. A critic of Zardari believed that he had such a convoluted approach that if you drove a nail through it, it would come out a screw.

Meanwhile, the biggest impact of the dither-